Antidote to the incumbency curse: Mexico's reelection reform and municipal races 1997–2025*

Eric Magar
ITAM
emagar@itam.mx

March 12, 2026

Abstract

Recent research uncovers systematic evidence of an incumbency curse in Mexican elections. The pattern resembles those found in other middle income democracies. A study of marginal municipal races between 1997 and 2010 revealed a discontinuity in the likelihood of winning the next election, estimating a .20 drop in the probability of reelecting in time t+1 the party that barely won in time t relative to the party that barely lost. This paper replicates the analysis by extending the data coverage to the following decade, when Mexico removed single-term limits for municipal governments. I find that the incumbency curse holds for races with an open seat. But when the incumbent mayor was on the ballot, the discontinuity is systematically reversed for every party. An incumbent mayor with static ambition therefore shields municipal parties from highly likely defeat.

*I am grateful to Francisco Garfias, Susan Stokes, and to participants at Tec de Monterrey's 4th Political Science Conference for suggestions on a preliminary version of the paper; to Gabino Martínez Díaz and Rodrigo Santibáñez Razo for research assistance; and for the generous support of the Asociación Mexicana de Cultura A.C. The author bears full responsibility for errors and limitations in the study.

1 Introduction

When a party takes over the reins of government, should its future electoral fortunes be expected to improve? Or, paradoxically, could they systematically worsen?

The emblematic and best-studied case, that of the U.S. Congress, points toward a substantial improvement in electoral fortunes. The incumbency advantage is such that it discourages the most serious challengers, who prefer to wait for better opportunities, resulting in comfortable victory margins for the incumbent and reelection rates exceeding 90 percent election after election.[1] After 1955, Republicans had to wait almost the remainder of the twentieth century to wrest control of the House of Representatives from the Democrats.

I focus on municipal governments. Budget allocations, administrative appointments, and regulation through municipal ordinances are among the resources available to reward the electoral coalition from city hall. By channeling substantive benefits toward the groups that comprise it, these tools help sustain their loyalty to the party in future elections (Cox and McCubbins 1986; Díaz Cayeros, Estévez and Magaloni 2016; Stokes 2005). However, it is also possible that these groups may have forged relationships not with the party itself but with one of its factions or cliques, and that such relationships may even be personal in nature (Cain, Ferejohn and Fiorina 1987). In such cases, any shift in the balance among factions could cast doubt on their future loyalty to the party.

Lucardi and Rosas (2016) examined this question for Mexico, inspired by evidence from Brazil, India, Romania, and Zambia. In all these cases, social science research documents a systematic *decline* in the probability of future victories for the governing party,[2] particularly at the sub-national level. Their analysis of municipal elections between 1997 and 2010 confirmed that Mexico follows the same pattern: governing today comes at the expense of winning again tomorrow.

This article presents preliminary results, incorporating a dimension absent from the original study: the possibility that the sitting mayor seeks reelection. Extending the Lucardi–Rosas model to the period following the adoption of this institution in Mexico reveals that the incumbency curse is conditioned by the retirement of the outgoing mayor. The curse appears to vanish for all major parties, when the incumbent mayor exhibits what Schlesinger (1966) calls static ambition, that is, the desire to seek consecutive reelection to the same office. The argument unfolds as follows. The second section discusses the 2018 reelection reform and its recent counterreform. I then introduce marginal elections, the device exploited by the research design to measure the effect of the reform. The fourth section

[1] Ansolabehere, Gerber and Snyder (2002); Cox and Katz (1996); Erikson (1971); Gelman and King (1991); Jacobson (1987); Mayhew (1974*b*).

[2] Brambor and Ceneviva (2012); Klašnja and Titiunik (2023); Uppal (2009).

Kick-off year	N states	States	N municipalities per cycle
2018	23	All others	1,382–1,388
2019	3	Aguascalientes, Baja California, Durango	55–57
2021	2	Mexico City, Puebla	233
2024	2	Nayarit, Tlaxcala	80
No reform	2	Hidalgo, Veracruz	296

Table 1: The municipal electoral reform. The kick-off indicates the first year incumbent municipal officers could run for reelection. The number of observations per cycle varies because new municipalities were created in the period. Source: Magar (2026).

specifies a model that replicates Lucardi–Rosas while controlling for consecutive municipal reelection. After that . . .

Eric: Revisar esto Novaes and Schiumerini (2022); Schiumerini (2025).

2 Electoral reform

To everyone's surprise, electoral reformers in the middle of last decade eliminated the long-standing constitutional ban on consecutive reelection for municipal presidents and council members (Magar 2026). Beginning in 2018, each state could decide whether to allow municipal authorities to seek consecutive reelection for one additional term only. With the exception of Hidalgo and Veracruz, all states allowed it, although at different times, as reported in Table 1. Twenty-three states kicked-off reelection in 2018, removing single-term limits for a total of 1,382 municipal presidents whose terms ended that year. Three states did so in 2019, two in 2021, and the last two in 2024.

Reformers never fully embraced the institution of reelection. For one thing, the move from single- to two-term limits was the mildest of feasible changes. And the new regime was lacking robustness: counter-reformers recently succeeded in backtracking, reinstating the constitutional consecutive reelection ban starting in the 2030 races.[3] Six consecutive years in office, up from three, hardly qualifies as a distant time horizon, yet the short-lived regime (2018–2029) offers a unique opportunity to study how consequencial the adoption

[3] A third aspect indicating hesitation was the reform's requirement that incumbents be renominated by the same party with which they won office, unless the party switch took place in the first half of the term. Formally, the party thus retained the ability to veto an ambitious mayor. In practice, however, many incumbent mayors in the data ran reelection campaigns with parties or coalitions other than the original. In all likelihood, the absence of an official record of party switchers and their timing among municipal officers (something that is routinely recorded by any assembly's steering board), rendered this requirement quite inoperable in municipal races. In practice, the requirement was constrained to legislative reelection only.

and removal of reelection was for local politics. Did the perspective of returning to office incentivize ambitious municipal officers to invest substantially in maintaining their electoral base alive and mobilized?

Motolinia (2026) is the most ambitious study of this brief Mexican interlude. True to a prolific literature initiated by Mayhew (1974*a*),[4] the inquiry focuses on legislative reelection only, examining the case of Mexico's state assemblies. The sub-national approach allows her to exploit the staggered kick-off dates to refine the empirical strategy. The study compiled and analyzed a monumental volume of evidence on state deputies (more than half a million assembly floor speeches, around ten thousand roll-call votes, committee assignments, as well as constituency service spending reports from thousands of members, and much more). Compared with other deputies, those who sought consecutive reelection doubled their probability of serving on committees with jurisdiction over particularistic policy (*pork*); made 2 percent more references to district-oriented *pork*-type projects in floor speeches; and reported constituency service budgets 15 percent larger. By contrast, metrics of party unity revealed no differences.

The effects Motolinia detects are systematic. As her theory of cross-cutting incentives predicts, they are notably small too. Party leaders' tight control of access to the ballot and the bulk of campaign resources leave little wiggle room for lawmakers to cultivate a personal, district-tailored style of campaigning. Perhaps there was not enough time for the institutional changes to mature. Or maybe the reform simply had no meaningful effects. Counter-reformers removed the chance to learn much more about this.

This article examines municipal *presidents* in the same period. Unlike legislators, local executives spend continuously. At their disposal are relatively small budgets (Díaz Cayeros 2006).[5] But combined with their modest regulatory authority, municipal officers have capacity to create winners and losers among municipal dwellers. Deciding who gets appointments in the palacio municipal administration and allocating services to sub-contractors are key resources in spoils systems. Which, in turn, could be used to cultivate a personal vote (Cain, Ferejohn and Fiorina 1987; Carey and Shugart 1995). I will show that the effects of the reelection institution—which, at best, appear faint in the legislative branch—operated noticeably and systematically among Mexican municipal executives.

[4]See Botero and Rennó (2007); Carey (1996); Carey, Niemi and Powell (2000); Cox and McCubbins (1993); Jacobson (1987; 1997); Jacobson and Kernell (1983); Kerevel (2015); Lucardi and Micozzi (2016); Morgenstern and Nacif (2002); Shepsle and Weingast (1994).

[5]Most income in most municipalities comes through federal revenue sharing and earmarked federal investments. But municipal governments also have some authority to collect taxes (Magar 2026), so, in principle, can loosen a hard budget by raising revenue.

3 Close elections and the incumbency curse

The literature inspiring this study places the focus in close elections, races decided by a small vote margin (Cox 1999; Mayhew 1974*b*). Despite taking place in very different regions, dates, and circumstances, close elections share a feature making them comparable: the winner is decided by the goddess Fortune.

To see this, consider two campaigns arriving to election day evenly matched: their candidates inspire confidence among similarly sized groups of voters, hits and misses in the campaign trail offset each other, they command comparable mobilization muscles, and so forth. When votes are counted, the anticipated outcome is a tie. Which is broken by fortuitous events: that food poisoning preventing wedding attendees from making it to the polls, the polling station unexpectedly voided due to irregularities, or voters confused by the ballot design.[6]

The analysis of close municipalities approximates a controlled experiment. In the present case, it constitutes a quasi-experimental design to measure the effect of governing or being in opposition—treated as a randomized treatment—on the party's future electoral fortunes. If the probability of winning close municipalities is systematically higher where the party previously lost than where it previously won, this would reveal a *municipal incumbency disadvantage*.

Lucardi and Rosas uncover such a pattern for Mexican municipal parties, without exception. Table 1 portrays it (it is a snapshot of their Fig. 1, p. 70). The X-axis measures mg_t, the percentage margin separating the winner from the main challenger in the municipal election of year t. Cases where the party was the main challenger display negative margins; cases where it won show positive margins. The Y-axis measures p_{t+1}, the probability that the party wins the next election. One party at a time, they classify municipal elections in the 1997–2010 period into three groups: a) those the party barely won,[7] which appear on the right side of the diagrams, starting at the central vertical line; b) those it barely lost, which appear on the left side with negative margins; and c) all elections that were not close, which they discard from the analysis.

They estimate p_{t+1}, conditional on mg_t, separately for the left and right samples. The

[6] A memorable case was Palm Beach County, Florida, in the 2000 presidential election (see Cohn (2024)). The ballot was poorly designed, making a distracted or Gore voter an easy victim of inadvertently casting a vote for the third candidate, Buchanan. It may well have cost Gore the presidency. In Mexico, partial coalitions create room for asymmetric errors of the same nature: voters who, unintentionally, void their vote by supporting the coalition in places where it was not present.

[7] In their analysis, Lucardi and Rosas consider a $\pm 15\%$ range as the selection criterion. Since Mayhew (1974*b*), it has been more common to consider elections decided by a single-digit vote margin, $\pm 10\%$, as close. I adopt that criterion here.

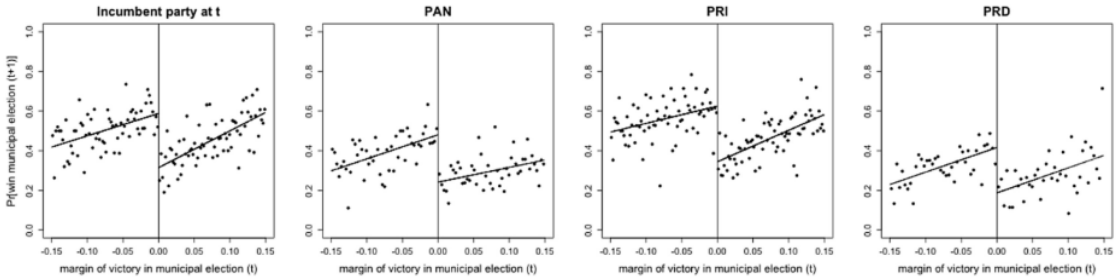

Figure 1: Resultados Lucardi–Rosas: la probabilidad de reelegir al partido municipal

gap in the intercepts of the dashed regression lines stands out. The estimated probability of reelecting the PRD and the PAN in $t+1$ was on the order of .2 when they barely won in year t, but about .4 when they barely lost in year t. The gap for the PRI is even wider, with probabilities of .3 and .6, respectively.

A paradox of Mexican electoral democracy: as if a curse fell upon city hall, the three parties of the partidocracy era doubled their prospects of winning the next election simply by remaining in the opposition.

4 A model with consecutive reelection

Shortly after the period analyzed by Lucardi–Rosas, the reelection reform took place, with the potential to shake up municipal elections in Mexico. Beginning with the 2018 elections, the prohibition on the consecutive reelection of municipal authorities was progressively eliminated.

If, as suggested above, the obstacle faced by the municipal party has been persuading the electoral coalition that another term "under new management" would maintain the previous redistribution, then the reformers directly and squarely intervened in the problem. Because, through the personal vote (Cain, Ferejohn and Fiorina 1987), the mayor's renomination should mitigate that distrust. And perhaps bring an end to the incumbency curse.

To evaluate this hypothesis, I replicate the Lucardi–Rosas model while controlling for static ambition. To analyze the probability p_{t+1}, I estimate the following regime-switching model:

			2018–2025					
	(1)		(2)		(3)		(4)	
	1997–2017		Pre-kick-off		Post-kick-off		1997–2025	
Partido	opos.	ocup.	opos.	ocup.	opos.	ocup.	Total	N
Izquierda	35.0	38.7	1.6	1.5	11.7	11.5	100.0	3,896
PAN	32.1	32.9	1.4	1.3	15.1	17.2	100.0	5,623
PRI	39.6	35.1	0.9	1.0	12.0	11.3	100.0	7,868

Table 2: Three subsets of close elections in 1997–2025 used for the estimations. Before 2015, the left corresponds to the PRD; starting in 2018 it corresponds to Morena; and in the intervening years it refers to either of the two. Sources: Magar (2026).

$$\begin{aligned}\text{logit}\big(p_{t+1}\big) = \quad & \text{neg}_t \times (\alpha_0 + \alpha_1 \text{inc}_{t+1} + \alpha_2 \text{mg}_t + \alpha_3 \text{inc}_{t+1} \times \text{mg}_t) \\ + \; & (1 - \text{neg}_t) \times (\beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{inc}_{t+1} + \beta_2 \text{mg}_t + \beta_3 \text{inc}_{t+1} \times \text{mg}_t) \\ + \; & \text{error}_{t+1}\end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where mg_t is the independent variable already introduced. On the right-hand side it is accompanied by two dichotomous indicators and a random disturbance. The variable neg_t takes the value one when $\text{mg}_t < 0$ and zero when $\text{mg}_t > 0$. In the specification, neg_t indicates the change in the estimation regime (the discontinuity): the β parameters capture effects when the party entered government in t, while the α parameters capture effects when it remained out of office in that year.

And the indicator inc_{t+1} takes the value one when the incumbent mayor runs for re-election in $t+1$, and zero otherwise. It allows for a shift in the intercept for elections with/without the incumbent on the ballot. Its multiplicative interaction with the margin in equation 1 also estimates a possible change in slope.

5 Data subsets for analysis

Three obstacles to the study of single-term limit removal can be anticipated. One is associated with the collapse of the party system, one with competitors' self-selection, one with the ubiquity of electoral coalitions.

5.1 The AMLO obstacle

A critical election took place when the reform was set in motion. AMLO's landslide victory in the 2018 presidential election inaugurated a new party system. Morena, a splinter from the left, became rallying point, realigning voters from all three former major parties and independents too, thus achieving majority status that had eluded the former PAN–PRI–PRD troika.

And concurrence raises a problem of overdetermination: if the probability of the incumbent party's reelection budged, is change attributable to the end of the reelection ban? To the party system? To both? If they pulled in opposite directions, the reform and Morena's sweep would cancel each other, partially or totally.

I knock over this obstacle like Motolinia does, exploiting the staggered reform kick-off calendar as leverage. I proceed with analysis of different subsets of observations, summarized in Table 2.

For all my estimations I select exclusively close municipal elections ($\pm 10\%$) in the period of democratic elections beginning in 1997. Column (4) reports the number of observations for each party. I begin by estimating the models using the full set of elections from 1997–2025, which includes (and thus conflates) both the tripartite system of democratization and the Obradorista system that replaced it. The number of observations for the left, the PAN, and the PRI varies because I include those municipalities where, in the previous cycle, each party either narrowly won or narrowly finished in second place. The obstacle is particularly evident in the case of the left, since I had to select two parties: from 2018 onward this refers to Morena, before 2015 to the PRD, and between 2015 and 2017 to either of these two parties.[8]

To attempt to circumvent this obstacle, I then estimate the models for the 2018–2025 period, the Obradorista party system. I analyze separately two mutually exclusive subsets of observations. The first corresponds to the states that, after AMLO's critical election, had not yet given the starting signal for municipal reelection (column 2). These allow us to verify whether the Lucardi–Rosas patterns replicate, in the absence of the reelection institution, after AMLO's election in 2018, which was concurrent with the municipal contests. The second subset corresponds to the states that had already adopted the reelection reform, where one would expect a possible change as a consequence of the new institution (column 3).

[8]There are three observations between 2015 and 2017 in which the winner and the runner-up corresponded to Morena and the PRD. I removed these three observations from the sample. There were only three because the lack of coordination that Morena introduced into the electoral left beginning in 2015 often pushed both parties below the margin, granting artificial victories to the PRI.

	Post-kick-off						
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	
Years	Incum-bent ran	Term limit	Open seat	Pre-kick-off	Non reformers	Total	*N*
2018–2020	30	0	51	13	5	100	1,745
2021–2023	32	14	39	4	11	100	1,955
2024–2026	38	16	31	0	15	100	2,039
Total	34	11	39	5	10	100	5,739

Table 3: Tickets with and without an incumbent municipal president running 2018–2025. Columns 2–5 distinguish the cases with no incumbent running. Sources: Magar (2026).

(Finally, the appendix also replicates the estimation for the 1997–2017 period (column 1), in order to corroborate that my study finds patterns identical to those of Lucardi–Rosas.)

5.2 Self-selection

The first obstacle is that municipal presidents have some degree of agency in deciding whether to seek consecutive reelection or to refrain from doing so. Table 3 shows that 38 percent of incumbents in the period ran for reelection. While this figure signals enthusiasm for the reform among municipal officeholders, it also reports that 44 percent did not run despite having the opportunity to do so. This self-selection should magnify the effect on the probability I seek to measure. To see this, imagine two types of mayors: those who anticipate an impossible reelection campaign, and those who expect a campaign without major difficulties. If these expectations were accurate and all incumbents ran, the first group would obtain noticeably less favorable results, and much higher defeat rates, than the second. This should also push them to withdraw with greater probability than the latter, thereby widening margins and reelection rates.

This phenomenon is problematic for anyone seeking an identification strategy for the causal effect of ending the prohibition (the treatment) *without* this self-selection effect.[9] By contrast, I am interested in measuring both together, because consecutive reelection is an institution designed precisely to allow those with advantages, those who have cultivated their electoral coalition, to in fact *self-select* into running again. From the perspective of my argument, the first is simply not an obstacle: self-selection is something I seek to capture empirically.

[9] And it could be mitigated with empirical indicators—which I do not have—to distinguish voluntary withdrawals, of the kind just discussed, from those driven by reasons orthogonal to expectations, such as when a party successfully vetoes a mayor's reelection ambitions.

5.3 Coalitions

The third obstacle arises from the frequent pre-electoral coalitions formed by parties. Magar (2026) and Spoon and Pulido Gómez (2017) provide further detail. Proscribed during the classic PRI era, democratization made them common rather quickly. For the 2006–2008 cycle, for example, four out of five municipal elections featured one or more coalitions, and the proportion has remained similar to this day.

Originally these were coalitions between a major party (the PRI, PAN, or PRD) and one or more opportunistic minor parties (PVEM, PT, etc.), aimed at refreshing the vote and improving the major party's chances of victory. But since 2010 anti-PRI coalitions between the PAN and the PRD became common. And after 2018, anti-Morena coalitions among the PAN, PRI, and PRD.

The difficulty for the analyst is one of attribution: to which of the coalition parties should victory or defeat be assigned? The selection of close municipal elections requires an indicator of the parties that finished in first and second place. It seems safe to award the victory to the major party when it coalitions only with minor parties. But doubts arise when coalitions involve more than one major party. Consider, for example, the municipality of Durango, which the PAN–PRD coalition won in 2016. In 2019 the PAN won on its own; in 2022 the PAN–PRI–PRD coalition prevailed; and in 2025 Toño Ochoa was reelected mayor but with a PAN–PRI coalition. A literal reading would indicate that the PRD won in 2016 and in 2022, and lost in the other years. If, instead, we incorporated knowledge of Durango's party system, we would discount the PRD because it is a very minor party in the state. If we further incorporated the fact that Toño Ochoa has been a prominent PAN politician, we would probably also discount the PRI in the victories of 2022 and 2025.

Unfortunately, I do not have this information to conduct a systematic analysis of thousands of municipal elections. The estimates presented below take a literal reading of coalitions. In future iterations of the article I will use finer classification criteria (such as coalition agreements, the governor's party, the historical vote share of parties in each municipality, etc.) to attempt to show that my findings are not the result of this particular coding of coalitions among major parties.

6 Results

I first present the patterns from the estimation using the full period before proceeding to a more fine-grained analysis. (For these initial models I used a Bayesian estimation with the MCMC method, and the diagrams use a sample from the posterior distribution—for

the final version of the remaining models I will use this same methodology in parallel with the standard OLS estimation of the models.) As in Lucardi–Rosas, the incumbency curse appears in the brown portion of the diagrams for the left, the PAN, and the PRI, patterns analogous to those observed above. The brown portion corresponds to municipal elections where the incumbent does not run, and the gap in the intercepts is notable.

The green portion of the diagram, by contrast, corresponds to municipal elections in which the incumbent mayor sought consecutive reelection. Three patterns stand out.

1. It is notable how the gap in the intercepts reverses. In statistical terms, it rather dissolves: if we estimated a single green regression line for both negative and positive margins, it would yield results almost identical to those reported.

2. In the right quadrant of each diagram one can distinguish, despite the noise in the cloud of green points, that static ambition doubles the probability that the PAN and the left win in $t+1$. For the PRI, which after the reform also lost its status as the dominant municipal party, the clouds overlap.

3. The left quadrants are the counterpart to the relative stability introduced by consecutive reelection. It becomes more difficult for all three parties to defeat an opposition mayor who appears on the ballot.

The key point: the curse of the incumbent party disappears when the mayor runs for reelection. Table 4 reports samples from the posterior distribution of several parameters of interest in the model. In every case the direction of the anti-incumbent gap reverses, although with mixed evidence. With an open seat, $\beta_0 < \alpha_0$ in the entirety of the 1,500 posterior samples from the estimations. By contrast, when the municipal president seeks reelection, $\beta_0 + \beta_1 < \alpha_0 + \alpha_1$ in only one-fifth or less of the posterior sample. The gap reverses four out of five times. This is no small matter. A mayor on the ballot acts as an insurance policy against negative partisan *swings*.

The estimation of models with data subsets for the 2018–2025 period appears in Table 5 and Figure 4. These are still very preliminary models, but they distinguish close municipal elections in states that had not yet given the initial kick-off (models 1, 2, and 3) from those in states that had already done so (models 4, 5, and 6). These are linear probability models of equation 1.[10]

[10]That is, they are linear regressions with a dichotomous dependent variable. In my experience, the estimates of these models always coincide with the more refined estimates of logit models, and they allow a direct reading of the marginal effects. The intention is to replace them with logit models and to perform Bayesian estimations like those reported above.

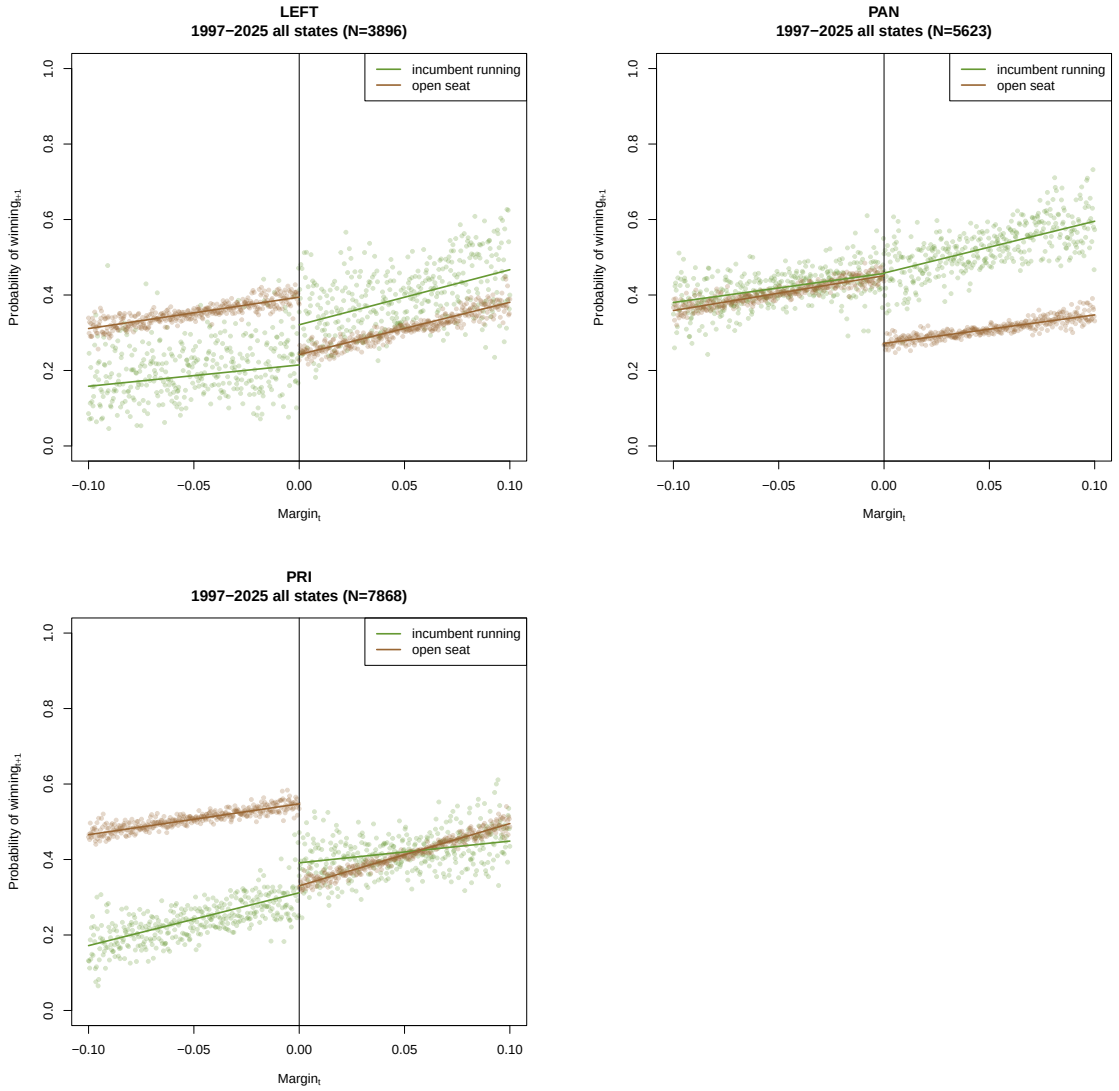

Figure 2: Simulaciones con datos del periodo 1997–2025. Método MCMC de estimación de la equación 1.

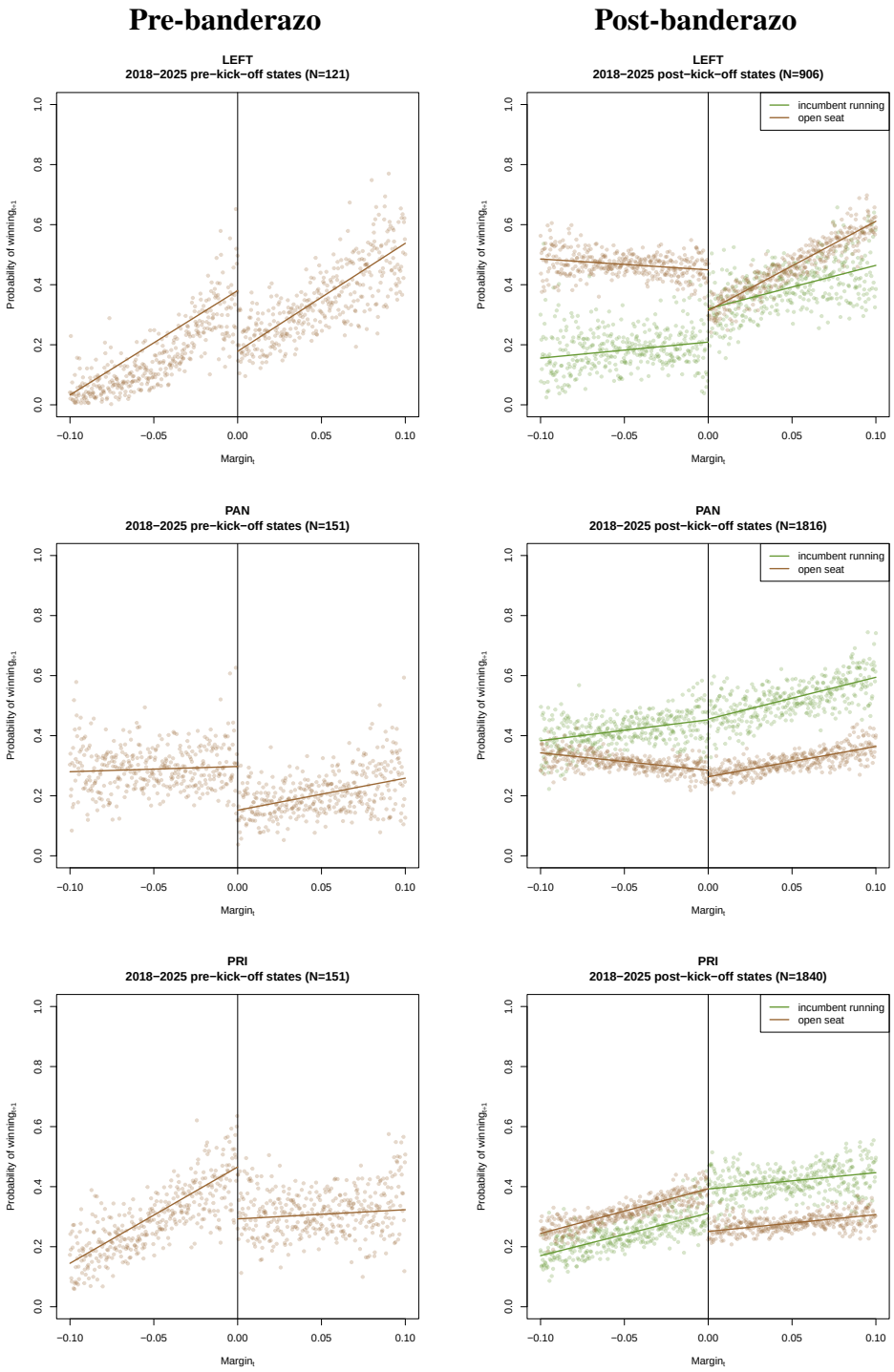

Figure 3: Simulations with the full 1997–2025 data. MCMC method of estimation of Equation (1).

	Party	Curse gap when no incumbent was in the ticket ($\alpha_0 > \beta_0$)	Curse gap when incumbent was in the ticket $(\alpha_0 + \alpha_1) > (\beta_0 + \beta_1)$	N
	1997–2017 all municipalities			
a	Left	1.000	—	2,869
b	PAN	1.000	—	3,656
c	PRI	1.000	—	5,877
	2018–2025 pre-kick-off municipalities			
d	Morena	0.916	—	121
e	PAN	0.876	—	151
f	PRI	0.858	—	151
	2018–2025 non-reform municipalities (Hidalgo & Veracruz)			
g	Morena	0.889	—	111
h	PAN	0.075	—	199
i	PRI	0.605	—	169
	2018–2025 post-kick-off municipalities			
j	Morena	0.984	0.219	906
k	PAN	0.677	0.488	1,816
l	PRI	0.999	0.177	1,840
	1997–2025 all municipalities			
m	Left	1.000	0.225	3,896
n	PAN	1.000	0.504	5,623
o	PRI	1.000	0.189	7,868

Table 4: Hypothesis tests. Cells report the proportion of the posterior sample meeting the hypothesized inequality.

	Pre-kick-off			Post-kick-off		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variable	Morena	PAN	PRI	Morena	PAN	PRI
When neg$_t = 1$						
Intercept	0.338^{***}	0.303^{***}	0.451^{***}	0.450^{***}	0.284^{***}	0.390^{***}
	(0.100)	(0.092)	(0.097)	(0.047)	(0.034)	(0.034)
inc_{t+1}				-0.230^{*}	0.169^{**}	-0.081
				(0.127)	(0.070)	(0.065)
mg_t	3.438^{*}	0.128	3.186^{*}	-0.339	-0.589	1.483^{**}
	(1.921)	(1.742)	(1.893)	(0.905)	(0.627)	(0.625)
$\text{mg}_t \times \text{inc}_{t+1}$				0.859	1.301	-0.076
				(2.305)	(1.304)	(1.205)
When neg$_t = 0$						
Intercept	0.174^{*}	0.154^{*}	0.292^{***}	0.311^{***}	0.263^{***}	0.250^{***}
	(0.094)	(0.084)	(0.102)	(0.050)	(0.034)	(0.033)
inc_{t+1}				0.012	0.193^{***}	0.143^{**}
				(0.112)	(0.073)	(0.071)
mg_t	3.480^{*}	1.059	0.409	2.952^{***}	0.987	0.559
	(1.874)	(1.756)	(1.999)	(0.932)	(0.628)	(0.602)
$\text{mg}_t \times \text{inc}_{t+1}$				-1.537	0.374	-0.036
				(2.049)	(1.338)	(1.296)
R^2	0.311	0.258	0.325	0.451	0.361	0.315
Observations	121	151	151	906	1,816	1,840

Table 5: Six marginal election models in the 2018–2025 period. 'Pre-kick-off' models include only municipalities in states where the reelection reform was not yet adopted, 'post-kick-off' only municipalities in the remainder states. The dependent variable in all models is the party's reelection indicator in $t+1$, fitting linear probability models with OLS. *Note:* *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

I will not dwell now on discussing the estimates reported in the table, in order to focus on the simulations in Figure 4. The results do not yet report uncertainty, only point estimates, but they corroborate the patterns observed above. In the period since 2018, in close elections prior to the reform kickoff, anti-incumbent party gaps are evident on the left side of the diagram. The right column, showing close elections after the kickoff, displays more differentiated patterns, but one can observe a fading (for the PAN) or even a reversal (for the PRI and especially Morena) of the incumbent party curse when the mayor appears on the ballot.

7 Conclusion

TBW

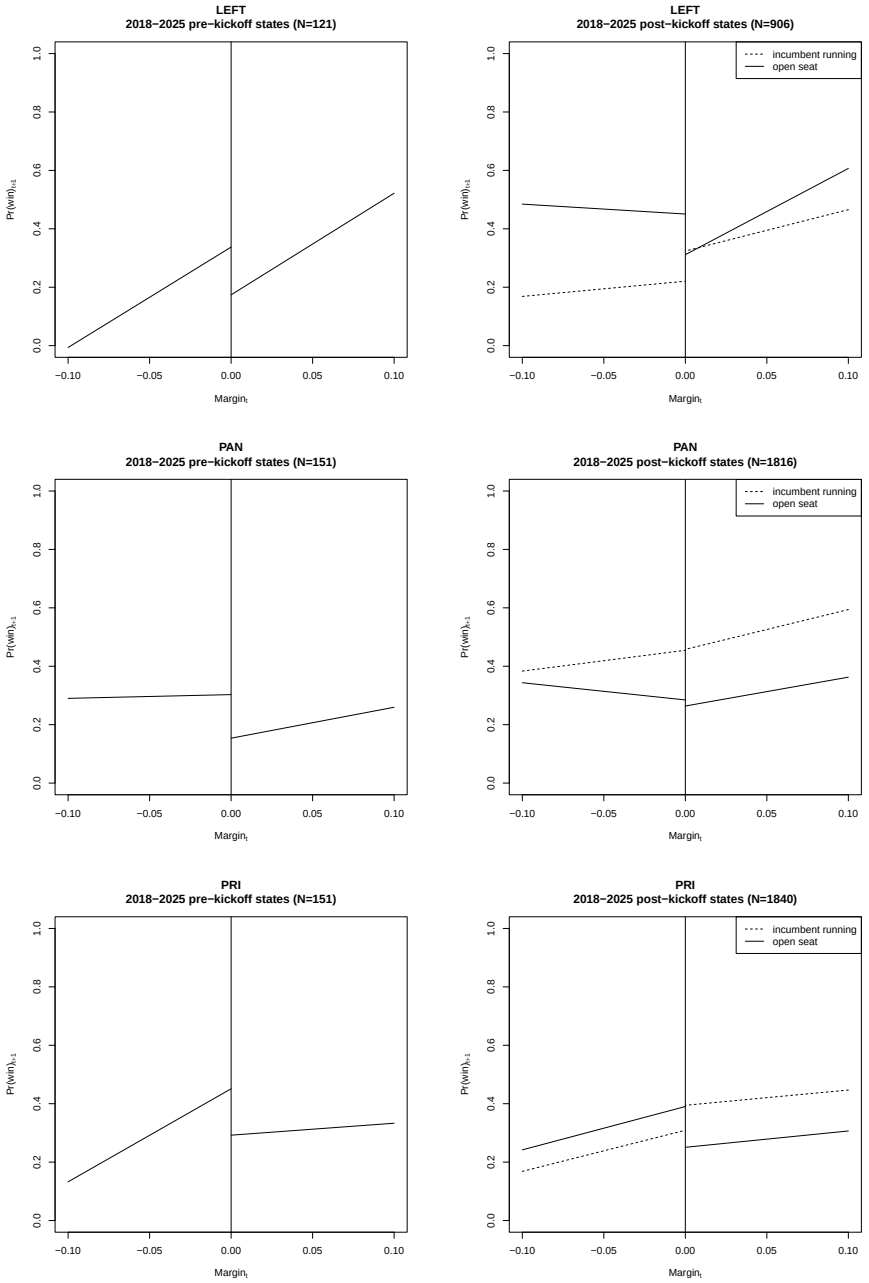

Figure 4: El efecto del margen electoral en la probabilidad de reelección partidista futura. Simulaciones con los modelos 1, 2 y 3 en la columna izquierda, con los modelos 4, 5 y 6 en la columna derecha.

8 Appendix

8.1 Model for MCMC estimation

```
library(R2jags)
logitModel <- function() {
    ### linear probability model with logit link
    for (n in 1:N){                ## loop over observations
        depvar[n] ~ dbern(p[n]);
        logit(p[n]) <- inprod(beta[],X[n,]);
    }
    ############################
    ## NON-INFORMATIVE PRIORS ##
    ############################
    for (k in 1:K){                ## loop over regressors
        beta[k] ~ dnorm(0, .0001);
    }
}
depvar <- data$dwin
N <- length(depvar)
X <- data.frame(
    dneg=data$dneg       , dnegxincball=data$dnegxincball
  , dnegxmg=data$dnegxmg , dnegxmgxincball=data$dnegxmgxincball
  , dpos=data$dpos       , dposxincball=data$dposxincball
  , dposxmg=data$dposxmg , dposxmgxincball=data$dposxmgxincball
    )
##
K <- ncol(X)
X <- as.matrix(X)
### Data, initial values, and parameter vector for jags
dl.data <- list("N", "K", "depvar", "X")
dl.inits <- function (){
    list (
    beta=rnorm(K)
    )
}
dl.parameters <- c("beta")
##
## estimate
fitjags <- jags (data=dl.data, inits=dl.inits, dl.parameters,
                  model.file=logitModel, n.chains=3,
                  n.iter=100000, n.thin=100
                  )
traceplot(fitjags) ## visually inspect posterior parameter convergence
```

	Left			PAN			PRI		
	point	.95-interval	$\hat{R}$	point	.95-interval	$\hat{R}$	point	.95-interval	$\hat{R}$
Model 1: 1997–2017 all municipalities pre-reform									
α_0	−0.503	(−0.70, −0.31)	1.001	0.107	(−0.07, 0.28)	1.001	0.338	(0.19, 0.47)	1.002
α_2	4.215	(0.45, 7.88)	1.002	6.509	(3.24, 9.82)	1.003	2.058	(−0.60, 4.82)	1.003
β_0	−1.241	(−1.47, −1.01)	1.003	−0.939	(−1.13, −0.74)	1.000	−0.605	(−0.74, −0.46)	1.000
β_2	4.314	(−0.01, 8.35)	1.001	2.895	(−0.47, 6.50)	1.001	7.566	(5.19, 10.05)	1.000
deviance	3475.1	(3471.6, 3482.6)	1.002	4763.3	(4759.8, 4770.3)	1.007	8029.9	(8026.5, 8036.6)	1.001
Model 2: 2018–2025 pre-kick-in municipalities									
α_0	−0.463	(−1.61, 0.63)	1.001	−0.860	(−1.75, 0.07)	1.002	−0.138	(−1.02, 0.76)	1.001
α_2	29.878	(1.13, 62.15)	1.000	0.845	(−15.85, 18.60)	1.001	16.373	(−1.49, 36.84)	1.003
β_0	−1.517	(−2.57, −0.53)	1.001	−1.721	(−2.81, −0.77)	1.001	−0.882	(−1.83, 0.06)	1.001
β_2	16.726	(−2.27, 36.46)	1.001	6.668	(−13.00, 27.31)	1.001	1.436	(−17.30, 19.56)	1.002
deviance	132.1	(128.5, 139.0)	1.002	169.7	(166.1, 176.3)	1.001	188.4	(184.8, 195.7)	1.003
Model 3: 2018–2025 post-kick-in municipalities									
α_0	−0.202	(−0.56, 0.15)	1.001	−0.920	(−1.24, −0.63)	1.001	−0.435	(−0.73, −0.14)	1.000
α_1	−1.130	(−2.45, 0.06)	1.001	0.731	(0.12, 1.30)	1.001	−0.358	(−0.98, 0.23)	1.001
α_2	−1.448	(−8.70, 5.73)	1.001	−2.693	(−8.36, 2.94)	1.001	6.948	(0.89, 13.09)	1.000
α_3	5.041	(−19.33, 29.06)	1.000	5.557	(−5.70, 16.49)	1.001	0.965	(−10.98, 13.05)	1.001
β_0	−0.783	(−1.18, −0.38)	1.004	−1.029	(−1.36, −0.71)	1.001	−1.094	(−1.43, −0.78)	1.005
β_1	0.028	(−0.95, 0.95)	1.002	0.849	(0.19, 1.47)	1.000	0.656	(0.01, 1.30)	1.003
β_2	12.350	(5.03, 19.75)	1.002	4.730	(−0.89, 10.67)	1.003	2.794	(−2.60, 8.55)	1.004
β_3	−6.231	(−23.32, 10.70)	1.001	0.890	(−10.37, 12.08)	1.001	−0.561	(−12.81, 11.22)	1.005
deviance	1221.2	(1215.6, 1229.9)	1.001	2307.0	(2300.8, 2316.7)	1.000	2240.9	(2235.0, 2250.7)	1.002
Model 4: 1997–2025 all municipalities									
α_0	−0.429	(−0.60, −0.25)	1.003	−0.197	(−0.34, −0.04)	1.000	0.190	(0.06, 0.31)	1.002
α_1	−0.868	(−2.09, 0.27)	1.000	0.025	(−0.54, 0.56)	1.001	−0.982	(−1.56, −0.45)	1.003
α_2	3.657	(0.47, 6.90)	1.003	3.841	(1.16, 6.55)	1.000	3.274	(0.92, 5.63)	1.002
α_3	0.094	(−20.66, 22.80)	1.004	−0.677	(−11.27, 9.83)	1.001	4.539	(−5.84, 15.80)	1.003
β_0	−1.141	(−1.34, −0.95)	1.001	−0.986	(−1.15, −0.82)	1.000	−0.707	(−0.83, −0.57)	1.001
β_1	0.392	(−0.49, 1.21)	1.002	0.817	(0.22, 1.37)	1.003	0.265	(−0.31, 0.84)	1.003
β_2	6.541	(2.92, 10.27)	1.004	3.540	(0.74, 6.42)	1.000	6.880	(4.72, 9.16)	1.001
β_3	−0.376	(−15.97, 15.63)	1.003	2.007	(−7.67, 12.18)	1.001	−4.515	(−14.92, 6.15)	1.002
deviance	4906.7	(4901.1, 4916.8)	1.003	7291.3	(7285.6, 7301.0)	1.003	10664.7	(10658.9, 10673.4)	1.000
Model 6: 2018–2025 non-reform municipalities									
α_0	−0.153	(−1.11, 0.77)	1.002	−2.068	(−3.24, −1.04)	1.003	−1.252	(−2.30, −0.28)	1.003
α_2	−3.291	(−24.42, 18.09)	1.001	−13.679	(−33.43, 4.76)	1.002	−0.811	(−19.62, 18.22)	1.003
β_0	−1.009	(−2.09, 0.06)	1.001	−1.031	(−1.91, −0.20)	1.001	−1.434	(−2.48, −0.49)	1.001
β_2	18.052	(−3.12, 40.03)	1.003	−2.396	(−19.02, 14.60)	1.001	6.165	(−10.93, 23.71)	1.000
deviance	154.5	(150.9, 161.5)	1.004	214.1	(210.5, 221.0)	1.000	190.7	(187.2, 197.8)	1.000

Table 6: MCMC estimates for equation 1 with different subsets of marginal races. See text for details.

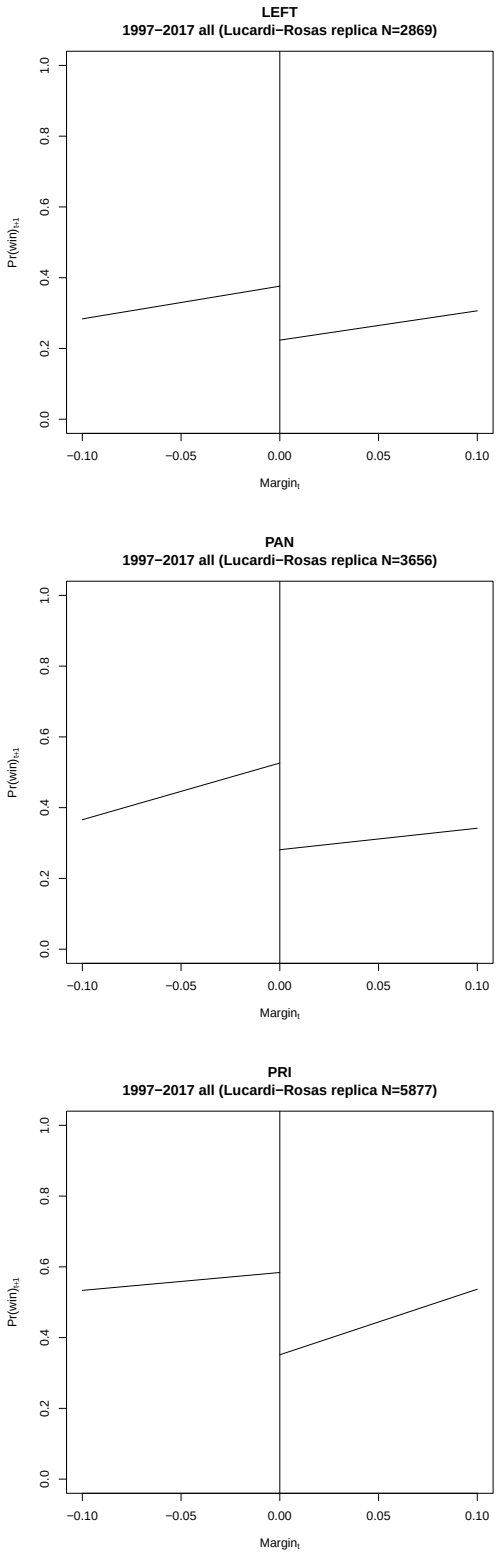

Figure 5: Modelos para el periodo 1997–2017: réplica de Lucardi–Rosas

8.2 Summary of MCMC estimates

8.3 LPM

References

Ansolabehere, Stephen, Alan Gerber and James M. Snyder. 2002. "The Incumbency Advantage in U.S. House Elections: An Analysis of State and National Offices 1942–2000." *Election Law Journal* 1(3):315.

Botero, Felipe and Lucio R. Rennó. 2007. "Career Choice and Legislative Reelection: Evidence from Brazil and Colombia." *Brazilian Political Science Review* 1(1):102–24.

Brambor, Thomas and Ricardo Ceneviva. 2012. "Reeleição e continuísmo nos municípios brasileiros." *Novos Estudios CEBRAP* 93:9–21.

Cain, Bruce E., John A. Ferejohn and Morris P. Fiorina. 1987. *The Personal Vote: Constituency Service and Electoral Independence*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Carey, John M., ed. 1996. *Term Limits and Legislative Representation*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Carey, John M. and Matthew S. Shugart. 1995. "Incentives to Cultivate a Personal Vote: A Rank Ordering of Electoral Formulas." *Electoral Studies* 14(4):417–39.

Carey, John M., Richard G. Niemi and Lynda W. Powell. 2000. *Term Limits in the State Legislatures*. Ann Arbor, MI: Michigan University Press.

Cohn, Nate. 2024. "Tilt Newsletter: Revisiting Florida 2000 and the Butterfly Effect." *The New York Times* .
URL: *https://www.nytimes.com/2024/03/30/upshot/florida-2000-gore-ballot.html*

Cox, Gary W. 1999. "Electoral Rules and the Calculus of Mobilization." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 24(3):387–419.

Cox, Gary W. and Jonathan N. Katz. 1996. "Why Did the Incumbency Advantage in US House Elections Grow?" *American Journal of Political Science* 40(2):478–97.

Cox, Gary W. and Mathew D. McCubbins. 1986. "Electoral Politics as a Redistributive Game." *The Journal of Politics* 48(2):370–89.

Cox, Gary W. and Mathew D. McCubbins. 1993. *Legislative Leviathan: Party Government in the House*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Díaz Cayeros, Alberto. 2006. *Federalism, Fiscal Authority, and Centralization in Latin America*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Díaz Cayeros, Alberto, Federico Estévez and Beatriz Magaloni. 2016. *The Political Logic of Poverty Relief: Electoral Strategies and Social Policy in Mexico*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Erikson, Robert S. 1971. "The Advantage of Incumbency in Congressional Elections." *Polity* 3:395–405.

Gelman, Andrew and Gary King. 1991. "Systemic Consequences of Incumbency Advantage in United States House Elections." *American Journal of Political Science* 35(1):110–38.

Jacobson, Gary C. 1987. Running scared: elections and congressional politics in the 1980s. In *Congress: Structure and Policy*, ed. Mathew D. McCubbins and Terry Sullivan. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.

Jacobson, Gary C. 1997. *The Politics of Congressional Elections*. 4th ed. New York: Longman.

Jacobson, Gary C. and Samuel Kernell. 1983. *Strategy and Choice in Congressional Elections*. 2nd ed. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Kerevel, Yann P. 2015. "Pork-barreling without reelection? Evidence from the Mexican Congress." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 40(1):137–66.

Klašnja, Marko and Rocío Titiunik. 2023. "The Incumbency Curse: Weak Parties, Term Limits, and Unfulfilled Accountability." *American Political Science Review* 111(1):129–48.

Lucardi, Adrián and Guillermo Rosas. 2016. "Is the Incumbent Curse the Incumbent's Fault? Strategic Behavior and Negative Incumbency Effects in Young Democracies." *Electoral Studies* 44(1):66–75.

Lucardi, Adrián and Juan Pablo Micozzi. 2016. "The Effect of the Electoral Cycle on Legislators' Career Strategies: Evidence from Argentina, 1983–2007." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 41(4):811–40.

Magar, Eric. 2026. "Local Competition in Mexican Politics since 1979: A Comprehensive Dataset of Municipal Elections." Available at SSRN: `http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.5400731`.

Mayhew, David R. 1974*a*. *Congress: The Electoral Connection*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Mayhew, David R. 1974*b*. "Congressional elections: The case of the vanishing marginals." *Polity* pp. 295–317.

Morgenstern, Scott and Benito Nacif. 2002. *Legislative Politics in Latin America*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Motolinia, Lucía. 2026. *Unity through Particularism: How Electoral Reforms Influence Parties and Legislative Behavior*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Novaes, Lucas M. and Luis Schiumerini. 2022. "Commodity shocks and incumbency effects." *British Journal of Political Science* 52(4):1689–1708.

Schiumerini, Luis. 2025. *Incumbency Bias: Why Political Office is a Blessing and a Curse in Latin America*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Schlesinger, Joseph A. 1966. *Ambition and Politics: Political Careers in the United States*. Chicago: Rand McNally.

Shepsle, Kenneth A. and Barry R. Weingast. 1994. "Positive Theories of Congressional Institutions." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 19(1):149–78.

Spoon, Jae-Jae and Amalia Pulido Gómez. 2017. "Unusual Bedfellows? PRI–PVEM Electoral Alliances in Mexican Legislative Elections." *Journal of Politics in Latin America* 9(2):63–92.

Stokes, Susan C. 2005. "Perverse accountability: A formal model of machine politics with evidence from Argentina." *American Political Science Review* 99(3):315–25.

Uppal, Yogesh. 2009. "The Disadvantaged Incumbents: Estimating Incumbency Effects in Indian State Legislatures." *Public Choice* 138(1–2):9–27.